

Supporting College Students with Intellectual Disability through Living and Learning Communities

By Charles B. Walters, Rebecca Smith Hill, Anthony J. Plotner, Andro Keck, and Han Wang

College programs for students with intellectual disability are designed to provide the same opportunities that all other students have in college: social inclusion, learning, and participation in classes and campus activities. The living and learning community (LLC) is one type of opportunity commonly offered at institutions of higher education (IHEs) that may have worthwhile benefits for students with intellectual disability. LLCs have long been used to promote the retention, academic achievement, and social belonging of college students (Eidum et al., 2020).

This brief details the process, findings, and implications of a scoping review of the scholarly literature on the use of LLCs for students with disabilities in college settings. Since we anticipated a relative lack of student participants with disabilities involved in empirical research on LLCs, our team conducted a scoping literature review to map and identify gaps in the current literature base (Munn et al., 2018). We examined the research literature on LLCs to identify salient information about their structure and utility for students with disabilities. Specifically, we set out to find the answer to one question: what is the scope and substance of empirical research on the support of college students with disabilities in LLCs?

What are Living and Learning Communities?

Living and learning communities (LLCs) are intentional, usually residentially based, groupings of students established by IHEs. They vary tremendously in their degree of coordination, purpose, and intended outcome (Stassen, 2003), however LLCs have been shortlisted as a high-impact practice in higher education (Kilgo et al., 2014) and have positive outcomes for students (Inkelas et al., 2023), including:

- student persistence
- college completion
- higher learning and achievement
- social belonging
- equity
- citizenship

In most cases, LLCs provide college students with learning opportunities outside of the traditional college classroom based on a theme (e.g., a sustainable living-focused community in a “green” residence hall) or an academic major that students have in common (e.g., an engineering-focused community in which a floor of a residence hall is devoted to housing a cohort of engineering majors). LLCs usually include a co-curricular element that is related to the theme or purpose of that community (e.g., structured service-learning opportunities in local schools for students in a teacher preparation-focused community; Dunn & Dean, 2013).

These outcomes are evident in the short interview that follows with Dr. Rebecca “Becca” Smith Hill and Andro Keck, a recent graduate of the CarolinaLIFE program at the University of South Carolina. As one of the first students with intellectual disability to participate in an LLC at the University of South Carolina, Andro offers some valuable insight based on his experience in a leadership and service-focused LLC.



Becca: Can you tell me what was appealing about living in an LLC? Why did you apply to live there your senior year?

Andro: I saw it as an opportunity to make new friends and try new things. There are a lot of common areas in the dorm where we can do activities or study together. My old dorm did not have common areas. We sometimes did art—and believe me, I’m not good at it—but I tried! And on Tuesdays, they had breakfast for us—donuts and hot chocolate or muffins or something like that. It felt good to know there is always something to do.

Becca: What was one opportunity you had living in the LLC that you might not have had otherwise?

Andro: I got to go on a Leadership Training Retreat. We went out of town to the mountains and got to know each other better. We did leadership activities, and I grew a lot.

Becca: What else can you tell me about your LLC experience and why it was important to you?

Andro: I felt welcomed from the first time I took a tour of the LLC. It felt like home to me. Everyone living there made me feel welcome. They encouraged me to participate in the talent show. And I didn’t do a talent, but I watched, and it was really fun. For me, living independently from the other CarolinaLIFE students made me have confidence to be myself.

Methods and Results of Our Study

A single member of a 4-person research team conducted a search of the scholarly literature on LLCs without parameters that might limit the search. Once we removed duplicate entries, two members of the research team conducted a title and abstract screen of the remaining 464 entries to determine if they:

- (1) were related to LLC (Yes or No),
- (2) detailed empirical research (Yes or No), and
- (3) were published after 1984 (Yes or No)

The team determined that 203 articles, including dissertations, met all three inclusion criteria and were retrieved for full-text coding. While the full-text coding process was created to help map the ways in which LLC researchers attended to students with disabilities in their work, the process began with a single “yes” or “no” question: are people with disabilities included in the sample for this study? Of the 203 empirical research articles on LLCs that were published after 1984, none had evidence of the inclusion of students with disabilities in their sample.

Discussion

Although the research team for this study anticipated the limited inclusion of students with disabilities in empirical research on LLCs in college settings, the findings were still disappointing. This rather dismal finding is contextualized by evidence that disability is markedly absent from diversity agendas in higher education (Scheef et al., 2020) and remains significantly under researched (Kimball & Thoma, 2019). Nevertheless, our review revealed there is a notable trend of examining the experiences of college students with marginalized identities within LLCs, including first-generation college students (e.g., Hall & O’Neal, 2016), gender in historically male-dominated fields (e.g., Rheingans et al., 2011), and race and ethnicity in IHEs with a white student majority (e.g., Mann, 2013). Given this evolution in the LLC literature, there is a strong foundation for similar inquiry that involves the lived experience of college students with disabilities.

Of the 340 postsecondary education programs for students with intellectual disability currently indexed on ThinkCollege.net, 127 programs report offering student residential services as part of their programmatic offerings. Nearly one in five colleges and universities offer LLCs to their students (Inkelas et al., 2023), making it likely that many higher education programs for students with intellectual disability are housed in IHEs that already have LLCs. Professionals working within college programs for students with intellectual disability can explore using LLCs at their colleges and universities, and colleagues in student housing or student support units may offer helpful insights into the availability of LLCs.

Recommendations

LLCs offer an opportunity for inclusion on a college campus, providing students with intellectual disability access to social, academic, and even potential employment opportunities alongside their peers. LLCs are established to bring students together around a common interest. Here are some recommendations for readers to explore LLCs with their students:

1. Continue Learning About LLCs

We hope this brief has been a good introduction for those new to the topic of LLCs. In addition to the articles we've described on the use of LLCs with students from other marginalized student groups, our search led us to several other informative articles about LLCs. Table 1 shows a selection of these articles.

TABLE 1. PRIMERS ON LLCs

Topic	Full Reference
Promoting social justice through LLCs	Jessup-Anger, J. E., Armstrong, M., & Johnson, B. (2020). The role of social justice living-learning communities in promoting students understanding of social justice and LLC involvement. <i>The Review of Higher Education</i> , 43(3), 837-860.
Campus engagement experiences associated with participation in LLCs	Smith, R. A. (2018). Connective segregation: Residential learning communities as networks of engagement. <i>The Review of Higher Education</i> , 42(1), 1-27.
LLC impact on broad student outcomes	Eidum, J., Lomicka, L., Chiang, W., Endick, G., & Stratton, J. (2020). Thriving in Residential Learning Communities. <i>Learning Communities: Research & Practice</i> , 8(1), 1-32.
Student social benefits of LLCs	Arensdorf, J., & Naylor-Tincknell, J. (2016). Beyond the traditional retention data: A qualitative study of the social benefits of living learning communities. <i>Learning Communities: Research & Practice</i> , 4(1), 1-16.

2. Talk to IHE Staff Who are Involved with LLCs

Once you have a basic understanding of what LLCs are and the benefits they may offer students, it's important to find out if your campus already has LLCs. If so, approach colleagues in student housing or student support (this is where LLC management is typically operated) to learn more. As demonstrated by Andro's experience, making in-roads to existing LLCs may start with getting just one student involved.

3. Promote Awareness and Training

Many professionals supporting college students with intellectual disability have found it important to raise awareness about the positive impacts of inclusion for students with intellectual disability and their peers and to promote a culture of acceptance and support within an IHE. A logical extension of such efforts may be to provide comprehensive training for LLC coordinators, resident advisors, and student mentors on how to effectively support students with intellectual disability. Training could cover disability awareness, inclusive teaching practices, and strategies for fostering an inclusive community.

4. Get Involved with LLC Research

Given the lack of existing research on the inclusion of students with disabilities in LLCs, there is a significant opportunity to conduct new studies. Such research could focus on the benefits and challenges faced by students

with intellectual disability in these environments or identify best practices for implementing and supporting LLCs that are inclusive of students with intellectual disability. The more we know about “what works” in the inclusion of college students with intellectual disability in LLCs, the better informed the decisions of our students will be. As IHE employees, many professionals supporting college students with intellectual disability are researchers themselves or well connected with researchers. Supporting this new frontier in research is a step that any of us can take.

Conclusion

Existing empirical research has offered little to illuminate potentially promising practices in fostering access to LLCs for students with intellectual disability, yet there are many documented benefits on LLCs in college settings. By continuing to learn about the topic, talking to LLC staff, promoting awareness, providing training, and getting involved with research on the topic, college programs for students with intellectual disability can create more inclusive and supportive residential opportunities on campus. This approach not only benefits students with disabilities but also enriches the entire college community by further fostering diversity and inclusion within an IHE.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

CHARLES WALTERS, PhD, is an Assistant Research Professor in the University of Maryland’s Center for Transition and Career Innovation.

REBECCA SMITH HILL, PhD, MSW, is the Associate Director of the Center for Transition Research and Leadership at the University of South Carolina.

ANTHONY J. PLOTNER, PhD, is a professor of special education and Director of the Center for Transition Research and Leadership at the University of South Carolina.

ANDRO KECK graduated from CarolinaLIFE, an inclusive postsecondary education program at the University of South Carolina, in 2023 and is currently living with friends and working as a server at a retirement home facility.

HAN WANG, MEd, is a doctoral student in special education at the University of South Carolina.

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